# INTRODUCTION | **ROADMAP**

## *American Berliners*

On June 26, 1963, President John F. Kennedy proclaimed, “Ich Bin ein Berliner,” from the steps of West Berlin’s City Hall. A year before, his brother Attorney General Robert F. Kennedy had offered a different sort of declaration in West Berlin. On February 22, 1962, Robert F. Kennedy arrived on an official state visit. He traveled through the city in an open motorcade, with over 100,000 West Berliners greeting him in the streets and later joining him for a speech outside on the plaza at City Hall in Schöneberg. On this trip, as he wove through the city’s western side, his itinerary called for stops at observation decks and border areas to assess East Berlin by looking at and over a six-month-old wall separating the two halves of a divided city. The attorney general’s visit occurred months after socialist East Germany began enclosing the allied sectors of West Berlin with an increasingly militarized barrier that reestablished the city as a front line of the Cold War. The border system, which soon became known as the Berlin Wall, emerged as a sprawling, interconnected structure merging physical division with symbolic control, marking the larger division of two geopolitical superpowers.[1]

At the end of the daylong visit, Attorney General Kennedy addressed another crowd, this time at the Free University, an institution founded after World War II, in 1948, with American support. He delivered his remarks on the stage of a packed auditorium, standing behind a podium carrying the logo of the U.S. Department of Justice. Kennedy was on a mission to affirm the administration’s promise that the United States would protect and, if necessary, fight for “the full freedom of the inhabitants of West Berlin,” adding, “and we have not forgotten the men and women of East Berlin and East Germany.” He continued, “Berlin will not merely exist. It will grow and prosper. We stand behind all these positions with the full strength of American power,” conjuring an undivided city. Throughout his speech, Robert Kennedy outlined his vision for how Berlin, both East and West, configured into an aspirational landscape of American democracy. He